

it is also illuminated by the roughly 450 illustrations that accompany the text. There is an exceptionally large number of outstanding colour photographs which often tell their own tales—the warm glow on the chert blades of the hunter gatherers of the Narmada valley which shows a refined choice of raw material; the spectacular Harappan cemetery at Sanauli in Uttar Pradesh, which has still not yielded the habitation that was associated with it; the exquisite coins scattered across the pages pertaining to early medieval India which make a mockery of those who see this as a “dark age” in terms of monetary history, and arresting images of well known sculptures like the Varaha *avatara* of Udayagiri as also lesser known ones like the Mathura relief depicting Siva linga worship, a practice that goes back to the first millennium B.C. if not earlier.

My only quarrel with this book is that in parts where a review of relevant factors warranted a trenchant criticism of existing frameworks, the narrative treads a more prudent path. This is especially true of the images from Vedic texts and archaeology between c. 2000 and 600 B.C. There is an acknowledgement here of the problem of dating Vedic literature and its geography and yet, it suggests that the texts can be used as sources of information. But how do we meaningfully integrate Vedic literature with the archaeological cultures of north India if we still cannot answer clearly when the texts were composed and where the cultures encoded in them unfolded? Archaeology fails to corroborate the Vedas and their “truth” can also not be “proved” by any Indian literary source since there is no body of texts which is contemporaneous with them.

Fortunately, the wonderful synthesis of the world beyond the pale of Vedic texts, peopled by cultures that Indian archaeology has done so much to highlight, makes readers move away from any kind of preoccupation with the putative Aryans whose horses have generally been harnessed, covertly and overtly, to larger agendas. Above all, this book on ancient India is neither agenda nor ideology driven. It is scholarship-based. There is no contemporary political agenda here, save to understand and appreciate the past as it should be. ■



Treasure Trove Diluted

The authors stumble on undiscovered archives documenting India's Olympic experience and add valuable insights to an old story



OLYMPICS: THE INDIA STORY
by BORIA MAJUMDAR AND NALIN MEHTA
HarperCollins
Price: Rs 695
Pages: 379

■ **By Dilip Bobb**

Serendipity describes events that take place by chance but in a beneficial way. Sports historian Boria Majumdar was given a scholarship by the International Olympic Association (IOC) for research at its museum in Lausanne. He stumbled across the India section of the archives containing memos, letters and documents exchanged between the IOC and Indian sports administrators over the past 75 years. Boria, however, was near the end of his scholarship. Serendipity knocked again. Nalin Mehta, a fellow researcher, had just bagged the same scholarship. Boria handed over the literary baton and the result is the first detailed history of India's Olympic experience. This is the first time that documented history has been used to tell the India Olympic story, one of sordid, self-serving politics, egos, power equations and regionalism.

What is surprising is how long ago the rot set in. The authors document the history of India's Olympic involve-

ment from the days when Sir Dorab Tata started the process, using his own money and donations from other individuals, mainly Indian princes who had Olympic-sized egos and played politics as craftily as the professionals.

This book uses archival material to show just how India's Olympic effort has been constantly hobbled by its administrators almost since the start. In that sense, it is a valuable addition to contemporary knowledge but it is not without its flaws. Predictably, hockey dominates but the detailed descriptions of matches is excessive and based on Indian newspaper reports. Then there are long chapters on the role of satellite television and the involvement of the army in sport, both happen to be subjects that Mehta earned scholarships for. There are equally long chapters on the Asian Games and the Delhi Asiad, where Mehta's grandfather played a key role.

There is also a lot on cricket, a subject Boria specialises in. The result is that the exclusive archival material the authors have dug up is largely overshadowed by other issues and personal interests that are only vaguely connected to the Olympics. The serendipity results in only the first few chapters being related to the “treasure trove” of archival material, which is a pity. ■